

What GNUKhata offers

- Basic bookkeeping including ten types of vouchers
- Viewing of the ledger in both single and dual formats (unique to GNUKhata)
- Three types of trial balances — net, gross and extended cash flow reports
- Project statement (referred to as the cost centre in other software)
- Balance sheet both in traditional, and sources and application styles
- Bank reconciliation module
- Three levels of user security — admin, manager and operator
- All the listed features are accessible to visually impaired users of computers too, as the project has ensured GNUKhata works with screen readers like Orca. A Windows version is expected to be launched soon.

New features in the latest version include the following: (i) A wizard to set up a company; (ii) A default chart of accounts to help you get started with your transactions; (iii) A new user friendly interface for receipt and payment vouchers, for people with no accounting background; (iv) A home screen with directions for getting started, useful for non-accountants; (v) Automatic accounting entries for sale/purchase invoices and credit/debit notes. All these features are GST compliant.

desktop based application. So far it has many happy users at places like the International Center for Free and Open Source Software (ICFOSS), Chinmaya University and some small and medium scale NGOs too. GNUKhata aims to grow into becoming a leading made-in-India and made-for-India accounting and inventory software. A lot of developments and improvements are currently in a very advanced stage of finalisation.

Today, the project's site lists a dozen-and-a-half active contributors, with many more having been active in the past. GNUKhata can be freely accessed and downloaded from <http://gnukhata.in>.

FOSS and the visually challenged

"It's wonderful. Wonderful!" KK says, when asked about the current state of FOSS that caters to the visually challenged in India. Being on both sides of the fence, he should know.

In fact, KK claims that now, the makers of proprietary software are copying a few things that FOSS software like Orca has been doing.

Orca is free and open source software, which features a flexible, extensible screen reader from the GNOME Project for the Blind. Using

both speech synthesis and Braille, Orca helps provide the visually impaired with access to applications and toolkits that support the AT-SPI (such as the GNOME desktop, Mozilla Firefox and Thunderbird, OpenOffice.org/LibreOffice, GTK+, Qt and Java Swing/SWT applications).

There's also a magnifier for people with low vision. Orca has a Braille-output, so those who are both hearing and visually challenged can use it to access their computers. It supports a lot of Indian languages, but KK feels the language output sounds quite 'synthetic' and could do with a better voice output.

KK does a lot of Python programming and Orca is also written in Python. This project started out in late 2006-07 and KK was one of the people involved with Orca. But then he shifted his attention to GNUKhata, around 2008.

KK has been a developer since 2002. He feels the only challenge in India is that people are not ready to work with visually impaired developers.

Quite a few universities don't accept the visually impaired to undertake programming tasks, he says.

To teach programming to someone who is visually challenged, one has to know how he or she navigates the computer, exclusively using the cursor. "We don't use the mouse. So, instead of saying, "Just go there and click that," you need to simply say, "Press the Up arrow thrice, the right arrow once, and then click Enter." That is the terminology you have to use while encouraging the visually challenged to enter programming..."

KK has worked extensively on GNUKhata. "It's my baby," he says proudly. Another software he has worked on is called MANTRI. "When elections come, everyone wants statistical and demographical data of their area. Interns at SNDT University (the women's university in Mumbai) were working on it. I liked it and thought it was a good graphical representation of the demographics. We called it MANTRI, for Managing and Editing Territorial Regional Information. It is written in Java."

KK says that he himself is totally blind and can only sense light. His mother came down with measles during her pregnancy, which affected his retina, and he lost his eyesight. "But my vision remained," he says with a broad smile.

Using GNUKhata

GNUKhata currently gets installed on Ubuntu and Debian. An RPM version is planned, and the team is talking with creators of other brands/distros.

"However, Ubuntu being the most popular distro on the desktop side, we thought it would be better to have the GNUKhata installer for it," says a project team member. **END** 

By: Frederick Noronha

The author is a journalist and FOSS advocate since the end of the last century. He co-founded BytesForAll, and set up the alternative book publishing venture Goa, 1556. He has been closely associated with FSUG Goa and ILUG Goa. He can be contacted at fredericknoronha2@gmail.com.